> We intend to convince the Soviets it would be in their own best interest to reduce these missiles. We also seek to reduce the total destructive power of these missiles and other elements of United States and Soviet strategic forces. In 1977, when the last administration proposed more limited reductions, the Soviet Union refused even to discuss them. This time their reaction has been quite different. Their opening position is a serious one, and even though it doesn't meet our objective of deep reductions, there's no question we're heading in the right direction. One reason for this change is clear. The Soviet Union knows that we are now serious about our own strategic programs and that they must be prepared to negotiate in earnest.

Through a heavy volume of phone calls and letters to the White House and public opinion polls after the speech, I felt I had convinced millions of Americans that we were on the right track with the Peace through Strength policy, but there was one person I did not convince that night—my daughter Patti.

Unlike many previous presidents and their wives, Nancy and I didn't have small children with us when we lived in the White House. Although they traveled east often, Maureen, Michael, Patti, Ron, and their spouses all had their own lives in California during the eight years I was president. Because of this gap of almost three thousand miles, we didn't see them nearly as often as we wanted to, and that was one of the things Nancy and I missed most while we were in Washington. We usually saw the children (and our grandchildren) at Christmas and Thanksgiving and managed get-togethers at the White House and the ranch. But we missed just being able to pick up the telephone and call the children and say, "Why don't you come over for dinner tonight?"